

Throughout the 18th and 19th centuries women's pay was generally two-thirds to half that of men doing the same job. In addition to inferior wages, many women faced unsafe or unsanitary working conditions. Many females (and males) entered the workforce while they were children, particularly in textile mills. They were employed because they were cheaper. Before regulations were introduced from the mid-19th century (first in the United Kingdom), children worked long hours, and often suffered injury or death in accidents. One of the worst industrial disasters was the 1911 Triangle Shirtwaist Factory fire in New York, where 123 women and 23 men died in a blaze, trapped in the building partly because one of two exit doors was locked to prevent theft.

Women unite

Spurred on by the Triangle Shirtwaist Factory disaster, women campaigned for improvements in working conditions. There were occasional strikes—for example, the Mill Girls of Lowell, Massachusetts, walked out in 1834 and 1836 in protest against wage cuts and rises in rent for employee housing. In 1844, they organized themselves into the Lowell Female Labor Reform Association, one of the first women's trade unions. Although women formed a minority in the trade union movement, where female membership was often discouraged or prohibited, by the early 20th century, tens of thousands of women had joined trade or labor



▲ Toil and drudgery

In the early 20th century, large numbers of Japanese women—often very young girls from the countryside—worked in the textile industry. They were generally poorly paid.

unions. One of the largest groups was the International Ladies' Garment Workers' Union, founded in New York in 1900. In 1909, the Women's Trade Union League (established in 1903) lent legal and financial assistance to a huge strike of mostly Jewish shirtwaist factory workers in a protest known as the "Uprising of 20,000."

The Industrial Revolution transformed Europe from a largely rural and agricultural society to an urban, industrial one. New inventions improved the lives of many people and brought prosperity for some; others, however, were held down by poverty and poor working conditions. Although female labor played a central role in this change, women continued to be socially and economically marginalized.

BIOGRAPHY

MARGARET KNIGHT

Born in 1838 in Maine, as a child Margaret Knight went to work at a cotton mill. Despite a limited education, at the age of 12, she invented a device that made looms safer. In 1867 Knight went to work at the Columbia Paper Bag Company. There she invented a machine to form flat-bottomed shopping bags. Although a co-worker attempted to patent it for himself, Knight was awarded the patent in 1871. She continued to invent until her death in 1914.

"[COMPANIES] SUCK WEALTH OUT OF THE STARVATION OF HELPLESS GIRLS."

ANNIE BESANT, "WHITE SLAVERY IN LONDON," 1888



◀ Overworked and underpaid

This 19th-century illustration depicts an exhausted young countrywoman on her train journey back home from her job in town.